words to that effect). Of course, the Chinese had led him by the nose to see what they wanted him to see. He was rarely out of the sight of his 'minders' who kept a close eye on him and the other Indian diplomats. Yet, allowing for the carefully curated programme and the effort to impress, he had come away shocked at just how far ahead China was in its development and modernity. While he had not changed his negative view of Chinese foreign policy and strategy, he admitted that the challenge for India was greater than he had imagined.

At the risk of caricature, we can say that it is a vital part of Chinese soft power initiatives to influence others by demonstrating the magnificence and inevitability of China's rise. Indian soft power initiatives rely on almost the opposite. Where China seeks to immediately overwhelm, to overawe by its size and (supposed) homogeneity, and to fascinate by carefully controlled revelations, India seeks to unfold gradually, to impress by its profusion and heterogeneity, and to disclose its soul completely. China is a seamless and material experience; India is a discontinuous and sensual experience. China evokes orderliness; India evokes fluidity. India does not signal inevitability, but it has its own magnificence: a British friend of mine who studied India and lived and travelled there explains her interest in India saying it features both 'the best and the worst of everything'. Few would choose to describe China in the same way.

It is almost certainly the case that China fits the spirit of the times and India never quite does. As a result, China has a soft power advantage that India will find difficult to attenuate. In 1958, the American social psychologist Harold Isaacs wrote a book on US attitudes towards India and China.[38] Isaacs interacted with Americans from academic life, the mass media, serving and former government officials, business, 'groups concerned with public opinion and education', and church and missionary groups. At the height of the Cold War and just five years after Chinese and American troops had fought a bloody war in Korea, Isaacs reports his findings: 'There has been over time a consistently heavy weight of favorable images of the Chinese stored in American minds . . . The sources of this difference are dealt with at length in this book. They are rooted